Multi-Type License Plate Recognition via Global Context and Contrastive Learning

Reference Research Paper: *"Improving Multi-Type License Plate Recognition via Learning Globally and Contrastively" (IEEE Xplore / IEEE T-ITS)*

Name: Adarsh Kumar

Roll No.: 26/AFI/024

1. Project Overview & Motivation

Automated License Plate Recognition (ALPR) systems are foundational in intelligent transportation and digital surveillance. However, conventional ALPR algorithms based on traditional morphological thresholding or standard 1D sequence-to-sequence networks (e.g., CRNN + CTC) struggle significantly when processing heterogeneous multi-type plates, such as multi-line layouts, variable aspect ratios, severe perspective skew, and low-contrast ambient degradation. This project implements and evaluates an end-to-end framework that captures global spatial interdependencies and leverages contrastive representation learning in the feature embedding space, directly addressing character ambiguity without cumbersome explicit segmentation.

2. Core Objectives & Technical Methodology

- **Global Context Modeling:** Replaces 1D horizontal slicing with a self-attention / 2D Transformer mechanism to capture 2D spatial interdependencies, effectively decoding multi-line and non-aligned license plate typography.
- **Contrastive Feature Learning:** Applies a supervised contrastive loss objective (L_cont) to maximize intra-class feature compactness while widening inter-class margins for visually confusable character pairs (e.g., '8' vs. 'B', '0' vs. 'D', '5' vs. 'S').
- **End-to-End Alignment-Free Recognition:** Eliminates heuristic hand-crafted pre-rectification and character segmentation by jointly optimizing recognition loss (CTC / Cross-Entropy) and representation discriminability.

3. Digital Image Analysis (DIA) Relevance

This work directly exercises core DIA principles: (i) spatial-domain enhancement & normalization (adaptive histogram equalization, illumination leveling); (ii) geometric coordinate transformation and projective invariant feature extraction; and (iii) modern high-level representation learning through spatial attention kernels and metric learning loss spaces.

4. Implementation Requirements

- **Datasets:** Public multi-layout benchmarks (CCPD, AOLP, UFPR-ALPR) augmented with synthetic multi-line plate variations.
- **Software & Frameworks:** Python 3.10+, PyTorch (v2.0+), OpenCV (Image Preprocessing & Transforms), Albumentations, NumPy, Scikit-learn.
- **Hardware Environment:** NVIDIA CUDA GPU (>= 8 GB VRAM recommended for batch contrastive feature pairs), 16 GB System RAM.

5. Phased Development Plan & Milestones

- **Phase I (Weeks 1-2): Data Pipeline & Augmentation —** Dataset acquisition, ROI extraction, spatial transforms (shearing, motion blur, contrast jitter), and benchmark baseline establishment.
- **Phase II (Weeks 3-4): Network Architecture Formulation —** Implementation of feature backbone (CNN/ResNet) coupled with 2D global sequence modeling and contrastive projection heads.
- **Phase III (Weeks 5-6): Joint Optimization & Ablation Study —** Multi-task loss fine-tuning (L_total = L_rec + lambda * L_cont), evaluating character confusion matrices and accuracy gains against baseline CRNN.
- **Phase IV (Weeks 7-8): Evaluation & Report Synthesis —** Inference profiling (FPS, latency), qualitative error breakdown on degraded samples, and final DIA laboratory project report compilation.